

combined population is less than that of Chennai, will test themselves against World Cup giants Germany and Spain.

Portugal, still nursing its wound from Morocco's conquest in 2022, will now be up against a Central Asian trailblazer in Uzbekistan, coached by a 2006 World Cup winner, Fabio Cannavaro.

Meanwhile, fellow Italian Carlo Ancelotti returns to the World Cup after three decades, and in the same country, the United States.

The decorated manager now adorns the role of tactician for the World Cup's most decorated son, Brazil, and the Moroccans will be giving his boys the biggest challenge in the group stage.

Old gods and new

The 2026 World Cup offers a last possible rendezvous between the two legends of modern football: Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo. The rivalry reached its precipice in La Liga, with Messi playing for Barcelona and Ronaldo for Real Madrid, but has remained barren on the international stage.

Across five World Cups since their debuts, there have been no clashes between Argentina and Portugal.

If Argentina tops its group while Portugal sails through as one of the top two teams from its own group, Messi, now 38, and Ronaldo, now 40, would hope to walk into a World Cup sunset with one final battle.

But in their dusk, a new rivalry dawns: the Nordic *'Der Bomber'* Erling Haaland versus the French talisman Kylian Mbappe, who has already won the World Cup in 2018.

Their duel, unlike the former, is

certain in a Group I clash and will dominate the headlines of most sports dailies the next day.

Soccer in America: Well, well...

Football in the United States remains the beautiful game that got away.

Though the World Cup draw at the Kennedy Center had far more razzmatazz than the 1994 ceremony, when the US last hosted the World Cup, it lacked the soul of a World Cup event, giving far more space to glamour than the sport itself.

The main draw, after the drawing of lots for the co-hosts, featured five sporting icons on stage: Tom Brady, Wayne Gretzky, Aaron Judge, Shaquille O'Neal and Rio Ferdinand. Only one of them, Ferdinand, had been a footballer and he conducted the draw.

For a country, the USA, to have won four Women's FIFA World Cups and still have no representation on stage was baffling.

Furthermore, there was no representation from sportspersons from Mexico, one of the co-hosts and the only one of the three to have been playing since the first World Cup in 1930.

If there were any doubts about a disconnect, they were cleared by TV presenter Dani Ramirez's daft question to Ferdinand, a former centre-back, about how many goals he had scored against Iker Casillas.

The US will have another roll of the dice in the summer when the World Cup actually begins, one that may finally test whether it can truly understand the sport it is trying so hard to sell.

World Cup Groups



Group A

Mexico, South Africa, Korea Republic, UEFA Playoff D Winner

Group B

Canada, UEFA Playoff A Winner, Qatar, Switzerland

Group C

Brazil, Morocco, Haiti, Scotland

Group D

USA, Paraguay, Australia, UEFA Playoff C Winner

Group E

Germany, Curaçao, Ivory Coast, Ecuador

Group F

Netherlands, Japan, UEFA Playoff B Winner, Tunisia

Group G

Belgium, Egypt, Iran, New Zealand

Group H

Spain, Cabo Verde, Saudi Arabia, Uruguay

Group I

France, Senegal, FIFA 2 Winner, Norway

Group J

Argentina, Algeria, Austria, Jordan

Group K

Portugal, FIFA 1 Winner, Uzbekistan, Colombia

Group L

England, Croatia, Ghana, Panama

DID YOU KNOW?

● Among the host countries, Canada will be travelling the most — 2084 miles — in the group stages of the World Cup.

● Among non-hosts yet to qualify, the winner of UEFA Winner Playoff A — Italy, Northern Ireland, Wales,

Bosnia and Herzegovina — will travel the longest distance (3144 miles). Algeria will travel the most among non-hosts who have already qualified.

● Argentina will attempt to become the third team to win back-to-back World Cup titles after

Italy (1934 and 1938) and Brazil (1958 and 1962).

● Haiti's gap between its first and latest appearance (1974-2026) at the FIFA World Cup is the fourth-longest in the tournament's history, after Wales (64 years), Egypt and Norway (both 56 years).